Name: _____ From *The Odyssey* by Homer "The Lotus Eaters"

TEACHER COPY

9.RL.1.A Explain stated or implied themes, analyzing their development over the course of the text, and the relationship of characters, setting, and plot to those themes. *Theme focus: How do the challenges of life affect a person?*

Odysseus as hero/leader | major event | setting | theme clue | ☆ clarify/explain

I Do

"I might have made it safely home, that
time, but as I came round Malea the current
took me out to sea, and from the north a fresh
☆ gale drove me on, past Cythera. Nine days I
drifted on the teeming sea before dangerous
high winds. Upon the tenth we came to the
coastline of the Lotus Eaters, who live upon
that flower. We landed there to take on water.
All ships' companies mustered alongside for
the mid-day meal. Then I sent out two
picked men and a runner to learn what race of
men that land sustained. They fell in, soon
☆ enough, with Lotus Eaters, who showed no
will to do us harm, only offering the sweet
Lotus to our friends— but those who ate
this honeyed plant, the Lotus, never cared to
report, not to return:
they longed to stay forever, browsing on that
native bloom, forgetful of their homeland. I
drove them, all three wailing, to the ships,
tied them down under their rowing benches,
and called the rest: 'All hands aboard; come,
clear the beach and no one taste the Lotus, or
you lose your hope of home.' Filing in to their
places by the rowlocks my oarsmen
dipped their long oars in the surf, and we
moved out again on our sea faring."

We Do: whole class

We Do: partners, 7 min

"Home" = Odysseus's GOAL. Watch this word → it comes back in lines 19 & 24. Repeated idea = THEME clue!

☆ 9 days adrift: wise to ride it out, or should he fight to steer home? (We Do debate) Nature tests patience.

Leader meets the crew's needs: water, food, rest.

☆ No weapons, no attack... the danger here is TEMPTATION, a sneakier kind of challenge.

MAJOR EVENT: the scouts eat the Lotus & give up the mission. Setting + weak choices = conflict.

HERO / LEADER: decisive, tough love. He makes an unpopular choice to save his men. Traits: responsible, determined.

Back on course: challenge overcome (for now). The plot moves on. EQ: challenges test focus & loyalty.

MAJOR EVENT: the storm blows them off course. Setting (current, gale) is the first challenge & it DRIVES the plot. (I Do think-aloud)

New setting: a calm, peaceful island after the storm. Mood shift = the calm before the conflict.

Cautious & strategic: sends scouts instead of risking everyone. (Remember the Cicones: 72 men lost!)

Sensory words "sweet" (ln 14) & "honeyed" → the Lotus FEELS good. Easy pleasure = a trap.

THEME DEVELOPS: giving in to temptation makes the men forget who they are & where they're going. The island = an easy escape from life's challenges.

He says the theme out loud: taste the Lotus = "lose your hope of home." Leads by warning & protecting.

Exit discussion (slide 23) – How did the setting drive the plot? The storm at sea pushes them off course → lands them on the Lotus island → the calm, "sweet" setting tempts the crew → Odysseus must act as a leader to get them home. Theme: giving in to temptation makes people forget their goals; staying on course takes discipline (and sometimes a leader's hard choices).

Teacher Key: Theme in "The Lotus Eaters"

Grade 9 · Unit 2 · Lesson 3, Challenge Accepted! · *The Odyssey* (textbook p. 721) · 9.RL.1.A

At a glance

Standard	9.RL.1.A — Explain stated or implied themes, analyzing their development over the course of texts, and the relationship of characters, setting, and plot to those themes.
Big Idea	Challenge Accepted!
EQ / EU	How do the challenges of life affect a person? / Navigating through challenges is a part of life for everyone.
Learning target	Annotate for character traits and major events; show how character traits and setting drive the plot, using specific details in annotations and the Facing Challenges Character Tracker.
Annotation codes	From the lesson: pink highlight = Odysseus acting as a hero/leader; circle = major event; ★ = clarifying / explaining (then write the explanation). Added for 9.RL.1.A on this key: blue = setting detail, purple underline = theme clue.

Theme statements to aim for

Accept any complete statement that the text supports. Push students past a one-word topic ("temptation") to what the text *says* about the topic.

Primary: Giving in to temptation can make people forget their goals and the people who depend on them.
Also strong: Staying on course through life's challenges takes discipline, and sometimes a leader has to make hard, unpopular choices for the good of the group.
Tie to the EQ: Challenges do not always look dangerous; the easiest path can be the one that costs us the most.

Stated or implied? Mostly implied (the men become *"forgetful of their homeland"*), but Odysseus comes close to stating it in lines 23–24: *"no one taste the Lotus, or you lose your hope of home."*

How the theme develops over the passage

Part	Plot (major events)	Setting	Characters	Theme development
Beginning lines 1–8	A storm takes the ships off course; nine days adrift; they land on the Lotus Eaters' coast.	Dangerous sea: *"the current took me out to sea"*, *"dangerous high winds"*.	Odysseus endures the storm, then lands to take on water and feed the crew.	Sets up the goal — *"safely home"* — and the first obstacle: nature.
Middle lines 9–19	Odysseus sends scouts; the Lotus Eaters offer the Lotus; the scouts eat it and refuse to return.	A calm, welcoming island; the *"sweet"*, *"honeyed"* flower. The Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm"*.	Odysseus is cautious and strategic; the scouts give in to pleasure.	The real challenge is temptation, not violence. The men *"longed to stay forever"*, *"forgetful of their homeland"*.
End lines 19–27	Odysseus drives the men to the ships, ties them under the benches, orders everyone aboard; they sail.	Leaving the island for the open sea again.	Odysseus is decisive and firm (*"all three wailing"*); the rest of the crew obeys.	Stated outright: taste the Lotus and *"you lose your hope of home"*. Resisting temptation keeps the goal alive.

Model response (characters + setting + plot → theme)

In "The Lotus Eaters," Homer develops the theme that giving in to temptation can make people forget their goals. The setting drives the plot: a storm pushes Odysseus's ships off course to an island where the people offer the *"sweet"* Lotus. Because the Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm"*, the danger is easy to miss. When the scouts eat the plant, they become *"forgetful of their homeland"*, which shows how easy pleasure can erase a person's purpose. Odysseus's response develops the theme further: he drives the men

"all three wailing" to the ships and warns that anyone who tastes the Lotus will *"lose your hope of home"*. His decisive leadership shows that staying true to a goal can require discipline and hard choices.

Discussion key (from the slide notes)

When	Ask	Listen for
Slide 20 · I Do lines 1–4	Think aloud.	Odysseus was on his way home when a storm threw him off his route. That is a major event because it takes him off course.
Slide 21 · We Do lines 4–6	What does drifting for nine days tell us about his leadership? Or does it?	Either side, with a reason: smart not to battle a sea he can't beat (saves the crew and the ship), or he should have fought to steer toward home and safety.
Slide 21 · We Do lines 6–10	Any major events? What do we learn about his leadership?	Reaching the Lotus Eaters' island is a major event. Stopping for water and a meal lets the crew recover their strength.
Slide 21 · We Do lines 10–17	What major event happens? What does it say about his leadership?	He sends men to learn who lives there; they eat the Lotus and never report back. Some will say the men did not respect him: they gave in to temptation instead of doing their job.
Slide 22 · partners lines 18–27 (7 min)	Highlight major events and where Odysseus acts as a hero/leader.	He ties the crying men under the rowing benches; orders everyone aboard and forbids the Lotus; gets the ships moving again. Note the cost: some men no longer wanted to go home.
Slide 23 · 5–7 min	How did the setting of the Lotus Eaters drive the plot?	The storm keeps Odysseus from home and brings him to the island; the island's Lotus makes crew members stop wanting to leave, which forces Odysseus to act.

Facing Challenges Character Tracker: sample rows

Character	Event / challenge	Quote (from the text)	Traits shown
Odysseus	His scouts eat the Lotus and refuse to leave the island.	*"I drove them, all three wailing, to the ships, tied them down under their rowing benches"* (lines 19–21)	Decisive, responsible, protective, determined
The scouts	Offered the Lotus by the Lotus Eaters.	*"they longed to stay forever, browsing on that native bloom, forgetful of their homeland"* (lines 18–19)	Easily tempted, forgetful of duty
Odysseus	Blown off course by a storm for nine days.	*"Nine days I drifted on the teeming sea before dangerous high winds"* (lines 4–6)	Patient, enduring

Exit ticket (3-2-1) key

3 major events: a storm drives the ships off course for nine days; the scouts eat the Lotus and refuse to return; Odysseus forces them aboard, ties them down, and the ships sail on.
2 ways setting can impact a text: it creates conflict (the storm, the tempting island); it shapes characters' actions (the men want to stay); it creates mood (calm after the storm); it can symbolize a theme (the island as an easy escape).
1 thing you wonder: answers vary, e.g. "Would Odysseus have eaten the Lotus if he went ashore himself?"

Look-fors and misconceptions

- **Topic vs. theme.** "Temptation" is a topic. Ask: "What does the story say *about* temptation?"
- **"The Lotus Eaters are villains."** They are not hostile. The danger comes from inside the men, which is why it is a theme about choices.
- **Who is telling this?** Odysseus narrates in first person to King Alcinous (in medias res). Extension: could he be making himself look like a better leader than he was?

- **Setting is more than a place.** Students should connect the sea and the island to what characters do and to the theme, not just list where it happens.

Margin notes as text

Line	Code	Marked text	Teacher note
1	**Theme**	*"safely home,"*	"Home" = Odysseus's GOAL. Watch this word → it comes back in lines 19 & 24. Repeated idea = THEME clue!
3	**Major event**	*"took me out to sea,"*	MAJOR EVENT: the storm blows them off course. Setting (current, gale) is the first challenge & it DRIVES the plot. (I Do think-aloud)
4	**Clarify ★**	*"Nine days I"*	9 days adrift: wise to ride it out, or should he fight to steer home? (We Do debate) Nature tests patience.
7	**Setting**	*"coastline of the Lotus Eaters,"*	New setting: a calm, peaceful island after the storm. Mood shift = the calm before the conflict.
8	**Hero/leader**	*"We landed there to take on water."*	Leader meets the crew's needs: water, food, rest.
11	**Hero/leader**	*"Then I sent out two picked men and a runner to learn what race of men that land sustained."*	Cautious & strategic: sends scouts instead of risking everyone. (Remember the Cicones: 72 men lost!)
13	**Clarify ★**	*"who showed no will to do us harm,"*	No weapons, no attack… the danger here is TEMPTATION, a sneakier kind of challenge.
16	**Theme**	*"this honeyed plant,"*	Sensory words "sweet" (ln 14) & "honeyed" → the Lotus FEELS good. Easy pleasure = a trap.
17	**Major event**	*"report, not to return:"*	MAJOR EVENT: the scouts eat the Lotus & give up the mission. Setting + weak choices = conflict.
18	**Theme**	*"they longed to stay forever,"*	THEME DEVELOPS: giving in to temptation makes the men forget who they are & where they're going. The island = an easy escape from life's challenges.
21	**Hero/leader**	*"tied them down under their rowing benches,"*	HERO / LEADER: decisive, tough love. He makes an unpopular choice to save his men. Traits: responsible, determined.
22, 24	**Hero/leader**	*"and called the rest: 'All hands aboard; come, clear the beach and no one taste the Lotus, or you lose your hope of home.' … hope of home.'"*	He says the theme out loud: taste the Lotus = "lose your hope of home." Leads by warning & protecting.
27	**Major event**	*"moved out again on our sea faring."*	Back on course: challenge overcome (for now). The plot moves on. EQ: challenges test focus & loyalty.